

“Why Does My Teenager Insist on Wearing Used Clothes?”

“Because I like them, Mom.”

Those are the exact words I say to you in annoyance whenever you criticize my outfit choices.

But, reading this article, I realized I would have to say a lot more to you if I wanted our constant arguments to stop. I’ve always been too frustrated to explain why I kept wearing clothes you deem unfitting, hoping that someday you would finally stop commenting on how I dress.

It never crossed my mind there was a “fashion gap” that I had to bridge with you. I guess I’ve just always assumed that, as a mother, you felt the need to control another aspect of my life. I guess I’ve never thought about how “[y]our reality” was different from my reality when it came to the norm for clothing. I guess I managed to build up walls around my explorations of my identity, preventing you from “prob[ing] a little deeper” to understand who I really was or how I was choosing to express myself.

And I was so unaware of how much research and communication you would have to take on to help me figure out who I am and “how that looks.” But if I’m unwilling to open myself to you, I’ll continue to dismiss your attempts at helping me with more “screaming matches.”

We’ll bridge the fashion gap together.

We’re in this together, Mom.